

Session 23: The Heavens

Key Takeaways

- In the Bible, the heavens represent God's dwelling place, the source of life, and the ultimate reality.
- Although God's presence permeates the whole universe (Ps. 36, 139), the heavens uniquely signify his dwelling place and the ultimate reality.
- The point of the biblical story is not that humanity will one day ascend up to Heaven but that the heavenly realm will come and transform Earth.

The Land Down, Out, and Under: The Wilderness, Abyss, *Sheol*, and the Grave

Jonah 2:1-7 NASB*

¹ Then Jonah prayed to the LORD his God from **the stomach of the fish**, ² and he said, "I called out of my distress to the LORD, and he answered me.

I cried for help from the **depth of Sheol**; you heard my voice.

³ For you had cast me into **the deep**, into the heart of **the seas**, and the current engulfed me. All your breakers and waves passed over me.

⁴ So I said, 'I have been expelled from your sight. Nevertheless I will look again **toward your holy temple**.'

⁵ Water encompassed me to **the point of death**.

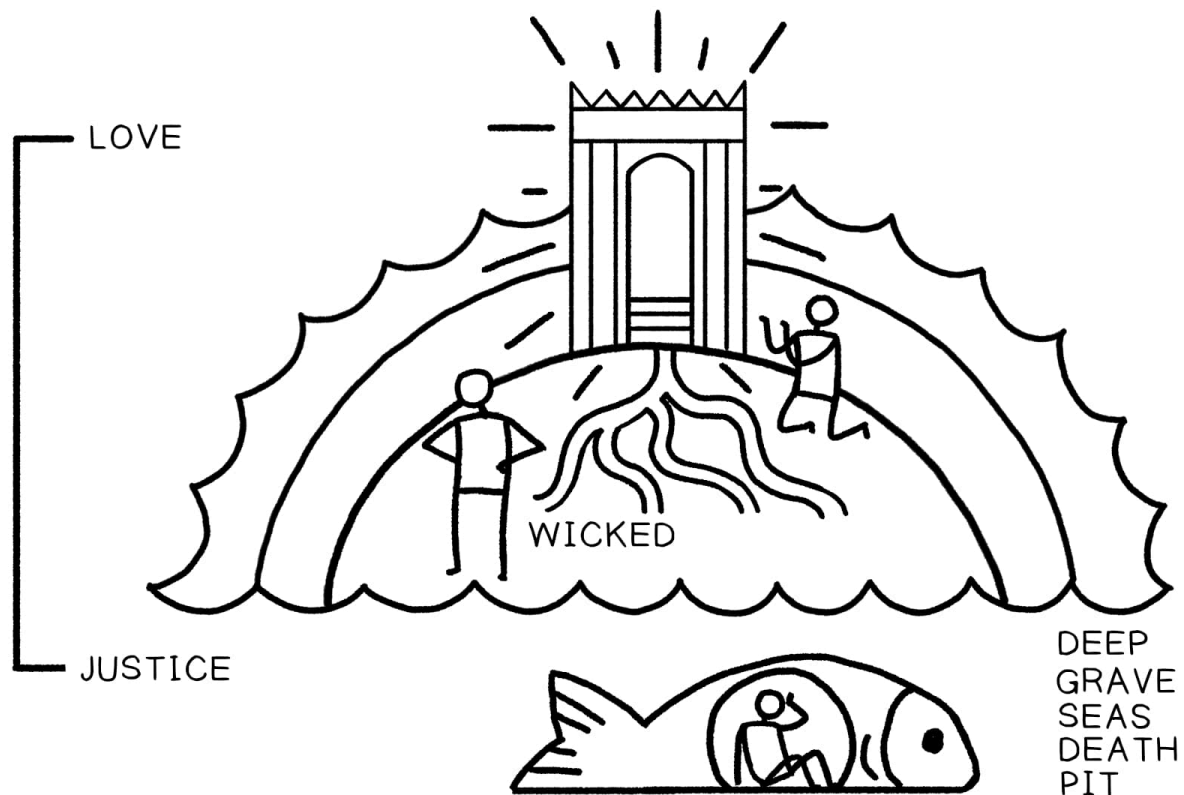
The great deep engulfed me, weeds were wrapped around my head.

⁶ I descended to **the roots of the mountains**. The **earth with its bars** was around me forever, but you have brought up my life from **the pit**, O LORD my God.

⁷ While I was fainting away, I remembered the LORD, **and my prayer came to you, into your holy temple.**"

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah's prayer connects his plight in the belly of the fish to biblical cosmology, evoking themes of the deep, the grave, the seas, death, and the pit.



Jonah's Fish as a Type of Wilderness Grave. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).

Wilderness in Genesis 1:2: An Image of “Nothingness”

Genesis 1:2 NASB*

Now, the land was **wild and waste** (Hebrew: *tohu va-vohu*)

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Other Uses of *Tohu* or *Bohu*: Empty, Uninhabited, Wasteland

Deuteronomy 32:9-10 NASB*

⁹ For the LORD'S portion is his people; Jacob is the allotment of his inheritance. ¹⁰ He found him in a desert land, and in the howling **tohu** of a wilderness; he encircled him, he cared for him, he guarded him as the pupil of his eye.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 24:10-12 NASB*

¹⁰ The city of **tohu** is broken down; every house is shut up so that none may enter. ¹¹ There is an outcry in the streets concerning the wine; all joy turns to gloom. The gaiety of the earth is banished. ¹² Desolation is left in the city and the gate is battered to ruins.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 45:18 NIV*

For this is what the LORD says—he who created the heavens, he is God; he who fashioned and made the earth, he founded it; he did not create it to be **tohu**, but formed it to be inhabited—he says: “I am the LORD, and there is no other.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 3:22-24 and Genesis 4:17: Exile “to the East” Into the Land of Thorns and Thistles

Genesis 3:17-19 NASB

¹⁷ Then to Adam he said, “Because you have listened to the voice of your wife, and have eaten from the tree about which I commanded you, saying, ‘You shall not eat from it’; cursed is the ground because of you; in toil you will eat of it all the days of your life. ¹⁸ Both thorns and thistles it shall grow for you; and you will eat the plants of the field; ¹⁹ by the sweat of your face you will eat bread, till you return to the ground, because from it you were taken; for you are dust, and to dust you shall return.”

Genesis 3:23-24 NASB*

²³ ... therefore the LORD God **sent him out from the garden of Eden**, to work the ground from which he was taken. ²⁴ So **he banished the man out**; and **at the east** of the garden of Eden he stationed the cherubim and the flaming sword which turned every direction to guard the way to the tree of life.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 4:14-16 NASB*

¹⁴ “Behold, you have **banished** me this day from the face of the ground; and **from your face** I will be hidden, and I will be a vagrant and a wanderer on the earth” ... ¹⁶ Then Cain went out from the presence of the LORD, and settled in the land of Nod, **east of Eden**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

City De-Creation Tropes

Isaiah 34:10-15 NASB

¹⁰ It will not be quenched night or day;
its smoke will go up forever.
From generation to generation it will be desolate;
none will pass through it forever and ever.

¹¹ But pelican and hedgehog will possess it,
and owl and raven will dwell in it;
and he will stretch over it the line of desolation
and the plumb line of emptiness.

¹² Its nobles—there is no one there
whom they may proclaim king—
and all its princes will be nothing.

¹³ Thorns will come up in its fortified towers,

nettles and thistles in its fortified cities;
it will also be a haunt of jackals
and an abode of ostriches.

¹⁴ The desert creatures will meet with the wolves,
the hairy goat also will cry to its kind;
yes, the night monster will settle there
and will find herself a resting place.

¹⁵ The tree snake will make its nest and lay eggs there,
and it will hatch and gather them under its protection.
Yes, the hawks will be gathered there,
every one with its kind.

Day of Atonement in Leviticus 16: The Scapegoat Goes Into the Desert

Leviticus 16:7-10 NIV*

⁷ Then he is to take the two goats and present them before the LORD at the entrance to the tent of meeting. ⁸ He is to cast lots for the two goats—**one lot for the LORD and the other for Aza'zel**. ⁹ Aaron shall bring the goat whose lot falls to the LORD and sacrifice it for a sin offering. ¹⁰ But the goat chosen by lot for **Aza'zel** shall be presented alive before the LORD to be used for making atonement by sending it **into the wilderness for Aza'zel**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Leviticus 16:20-22 NIV*

²⁰ When Aaron has finished making atonement for the most holy place, the tent of meeting and the altar, he shall bring forward the live goat. ²¹ He is to lay both hands on the head of the live goat and confess over it all the wickedness and rebellion of the Israelites— all their sins—and put them on the goat's head. **He shall send the goat away into the wilderness** in the care of someone appointed for the task. ²² The goat will carry on itself all their sins **to a remote place (lit. "a land that is cut off"); and the man shall release it into the wilderness**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

New Creation as Wilderness Transformed Into Gardens

Isaiah 41:17-20 NIV

¹⁷ The poor and needy search for water, but there is none;
their tongues are parched with thirst.
But I the LORD will answer them;
I, the God of Israel, will not forsake them.

¹⁸ I will make rivers flow on barren heights,
and springs within the valleys.
I will turn the desert into pools of water,
and the parched ground into springs.

¹⁹ I will put in the desert the cedar and the acacia,

the myrtle and the olive.
I will set junipers in the wasteland,
the fir and the cypress together,
²⁰ so that people may see and know,
may consider and understand,
that the hand of the LORD has done this,
that the Holy One of Israel has created it.

Other Occurrences of the Wilderness Pattern

- Summary of Psalms passage (Ps. 107:33-37)
- Jesus tested and victorious in the wilderness (Matt. 4)
- Demons and the wilderness (Luke 8:29)
- The harlot on the dragon in the wilderness (Rev. 17:3)

Sheol, the Watery Abyss, and the Pit

Recall that under the land was the abysmal waters, darkness, and death.

Psalm 24:1-2 NIV*

¹ **The land** is the LORD'S, and everything in it,
the world, and all who live in it;
² for he founded it **on the seas**
and established it **on the waters**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 69:1-2, 15 NASB*

¹ Save me, O God,
for **the waters** have threatened my life.
² I have sunk in **deep mire**, and there is no foothold;
I have come into **deep waters**, and a flood overflows me.
¹⁵ May **the flood of water** not overflow me
nor **the deep** swallow me up,
nor **the pit** shut its mouth on me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 88:3-7 NASB*

³ For my soul has had enough troubles,
and my life has drawn near to **Sheol**.
⁴ I am reckoned among those who go down to the **pit**;
I have become like a man without strength,
⁵ forsaken among the **dead**,
like the slain who lie in the **grave**,

whom you remember no more,
and they are cut off from your hand.

⁶ You have put me in the lowest **pit**,
in dark places, in the **depths**.

⁷ ... and you have afflicted me with all your **waves**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 18:4-5 NASB*

⁴ The **cords of death** encompassed me,
and the **torrents of ungodliness** terrified me.

⁵ The cords of **Sheol** surrounded me;
the snares of **death** confronted me.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 115:16-17 NASB*

¹⁶ The heavens are the heavens of the LORD,
But the **earth** he has given to the sons of men.

¹⁷ The **dead** do not praise the LORD,
Nor do any who go down into silence.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In the Bible, *Sheol* is the realm of the dead.

- "Below" (Deut. 32:22; Ps. 86:13; Job 11:8; Prov. 9:18)
- "The pit" (Jon. 2:6; Ps. 40:2; Isa. 14:15; Ezek. 32:23)
- "The depths of the land" (Ps. 71:20)
- Associated with dirt and worms (Job 17:16; Isa. 14:11)
- The cosmological opposite of the skies (Job 11:8; Ps. 139:8; Amos 9:2)

Psalms 139:7-9 NASB*

⁷ Where can I go from your Spirit?
Or where can I flee from your presence?

⁸ If I ascend to **heaven**, you are there;
if I make my bed in **Sheol**, behold, you are there.

⁹ If I take to the edges/wings of the dawn,
if I dwell in the end of **the sea** ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Metaphors Associated with Sheol

- Darkness, the pre-creation state of Genesis 1 (Job 17:21; Ps. 88:2-6, 10-12; Lam. 3:6)
- Locked with gates and bars (Jon. 2:6; Isa. 38:10)
- Half-sleep and weakness (Isa. 14:10; Ps. 94:17, 115:17; Ezek. 32:21; Eccl. 9:5-6)

- The home of defeated kings of old (Isa. 14:9-15)
- Home of the wicked (Ps. 9:17, 31:17, 49:14, 141:7; Job 24:19; Prov. 5:5, 7:27, 9:18)
- From it the righteous await redemption (Ps. 14, 30:3, 40:2, 71:20, 86:13, 88:6)

Psalm 9:17-18 NIV*

¹⁷ The wicked **go down to Sheol**,
all the nations that forget God.

¹⁸ But God will never forget the needy;
the hope of the afflicted will never perish.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 31:14-17 NIV*

¹⁴ But I trust in you, LORD;
I say, "You are my God."

¹⁵ My times are in your hands;
deliver me from the hands of my enemies,
from those who pursue me.

¹⁶ Let your face shine on your servant;
save me in your unfailing love.

¹⁷ Let me not be put to shame, LORD,
for I have cried out to you;
but **let the wicked be put to shame
and be silent in Sheol.**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 49:12-15 NIV*

¹² People, despite their wealth, do not endure;
they are like the beasts that perish.

¹³ This is the fate of those who trust in themselves,
and of their followers, who approve their sayings.

¹⁴ They are like sheep and are destined to die;
death will be their shepherd,
but the upright will rule over them in the morning.
Their forms will decay in the grave,
far from their princely mansions.

¹⁵ But God will redeem me from **Sheol**;
he will surely take me to himself.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 71:19-21 NIV

¹⁹ Your righteousness, God, reaches to the heavens,
you who have done great things.

Who is like you, God?

²⁰ Though you have made me see troubles,
many and bitter,
you will restore my life again;
from the depths of the earth
you will again bring me up.

²¹ You will increase my honor
and comfort me once more.

Other examples of restoration from exile as resurrection include [Hosea 6:1-3](#) and [Ezekiel 37:1-14](#).

The Heavens/Skies Above

God is depicted as dwelling above the heavens. This spatial image makes clear that the divine realm is transcendent and above all, a fitting place for God's divine throne.

Psalm 11:4 NIV

The LORD is in **his holy temple**;
the LORD is on his **heavenly throne**.
He observes everyone on earth;
his eyes examine them.

Isaiah 66:1-2 NIV

¹ This is what the LORD says:
**"Heaven is my throne,
and the land is my footstool.**
Where is the house you will build for me?
Where will my resting place be?
² Has not my hand made all these things,
and so they came into being?"
declares the LORD.

Reflection Question

How is the word "heaven(s)" used today, and how does this compare with the biblical use of "heavens"?